

there. A general principle is that, while in the first three quadrants you can use *the best* model or theory you can find, and rely on it, doing so is dangerous in the Fourth Quadrant: no theory or model should be better than just any theory or model.

In other words, the Fourth Quadrant is *where the difference between absence of evidence and evidence of absence becomes acute*.

Next let us see how we can exit the Fourth Quadrant or mitigate its effects.

- * This section should be skipped by those who are not involved in social science, business, or, something even worse, public policy. Section VII will be less mundane.
- * David left me with a second surprise gift, the best gift anyone gave me during my *deserto*: he wrote, in a posthumous paper, that “efforts by statisticians to refute Taleb proved unconvincing,” a single sentence which turned the tide and canceled out hundreds of pages of mostly ad hominem attacks, as it alerted the reader that there was no refutation, that the criticisms had no substance. All you need is a single sentence like that to put the message back in place.
- * This is a true philosophical a priori since when you assume events belong to Extremistan (because of the lack of structure to the randomness), no additional empirical observations can possibly change your mind, since the property of Extremistan is to hide the possibility of Black Swan events—what I called earlier the masquerade problem.